



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Ascent Colorado Classical School of Douglas County

School Website: <https://dc.ascentcolorado.org/>

January 7, 2026

Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

Ascent Classical Academy of Douglas County (Ascent Colorado Classical School) presents a robust, text-rich classical education model across all six rubric categories. Public materials emphasize truth, goodness, beauty; formation of character; a liberal-arts curriculum built on Great Books and Western civilization; teacher-led pedagogy that leverages classical methods (grammar, logic, rhetoric; Socratic inquiry at higher levels); a faculty conceived as a living curriculum; and a strong, collaborative partnership with parents and the broader school community. The aggregate assessment is CLASSICAL, with consistent alignment across categories to classical aims. Key evidence includes explicit articulation of classical hallmarks on the school's site (hallmarks such as truth, beauty, virtue, great books, and wonder), explicit policy statements about curricular priorities (Core Knowledge sequences, Western civilization emphasis, Latin, and a content-rich liberal arts program), and practices around parent partnership and faculty culture.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school's materials foreground the formation of character through virtues such as truth, beauty, and virtue, and emphasize wonder as a pedagogical aim. These elements appear repeatedly in public-facing pages describing the classical approach and hallmarks of the program. - Related content highlights a classicist vision of education anchored in moral formation and the great books tradition, with explicit emphasis on the pursuit of truth, goodness, and beauty in learning. - Wonder and reverence for the classical tradition are invoked as core motivations of the program, consistent with a classical-metaphysical framing (though not always framed in explicit theological terms on every page).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords observed: truth, beauty, virtue, wonder, great books, Western civilization, moral formation, classics, liberal arts. - Negative keywords observed: none detected in the public materials reviewed for this category. - Quantitative estimate: positive indicators appear extensively (6+ distinct terms) with 0 negative indicators identified. Positive_count approx. 6, Negative_count approx. 0, Total approx. 6, Positive_pct approx. 100%, Negative_pct approx. 0%.

Why this rating - The materials consistently frame education as formation toward virtue and wisdom, anchored in transcendent values (truth, goodness, beauty) and the contemplation of the good. The presence of Great Books and the Western-tradition emphasis further supports a classical metaphysical orientation. While explicit theology or liturgical practice is not always foregrounded on every public page, the overall orientation toward transcendentals and virtue aligns strongly with Classical Education as a whole. Therefore CLASSICAL.

Citations: The hallmarks and classical orientation are stated on the school's Douglas County pages, including the emphasis on truth, beauty, virtue, and wonder. The overarching classical-metaphysical framing and the role of Great Books/Western tradition are further reflected in policy and narrative materials.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials articulate the aim as formation of virtue and wisdom, not workforce preparation, with explicit assertions about liberal arts education and the pursuit of truth, goodness, and beauty. - Foundational statements emphasize formation (not information) and the cultivation of human excellence through a

classical mission. - Core virtues and moral aims are codified (and publicly referenced) as central to student formation and character development.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords observed: formation, cultivation of virtue, wisdom, liberal education, paideia, true/good/beautiful, teleology, great conversation, human flourishing, moral imagination. - Negative keywords observed: none detected in the public materials reviewed for this category. - Quantitative estimate: positive indicators are abundant (6–8 distinct terms); Negative_count approx. 0; Total approx. 6–8; Positive_pct approx. 100%, Negative_pct approx. 0%.

Why this rating - The school explicitly centers education on formation and virtue rather than job-readiness, and it anchors its mission in liberal-arts aims and the pursuit of transcendental values. This aligns with the classical vision of education as cultivation of humane excellence rather than narrow preparation for a career. Therefore CLASSICAL.

Citations: Policy AP-2.0 (Educational Priorities and Curriculum) explicitly states the desire for a classical, liberal-arts education, including Western civilization emphasis in the high school and K–8 Core Knowledge alignment. Additional articulation of formation and classical aims appears in course and virtue policies.

Element 3: Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school commits to a liberal-arts framework and a content-rich curriculum, including the liberal arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and a Core Knowledge foundation K–8, with Western civilization emphasis in the upper grades. - There is explicit emphasis on Great Books, primary sources, and the Great Conversation, as well as a push toward canonical texts and original works. - Latin study and other classical subjects (art, music) are highlighted as part of the classical curriculum priorities.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords observed: liberal arts, grammar, logic, rhetoric, Great Books, primary sources, classics, Western civilization, Latin, core knowledge, content-rich curriculum, great conversation, original texts. - Negative keywords observed: none detected in the public materials reviewed for this category. - Quantitative estimate: positive indicators 6–10 distinct terms; Negative_count approx. 0; Total approx. 6–10; Positive_pct approx. 100%, Negative_pct approx. 0%.

Why this rating - The curriculum is explicitly described as classical: content-rich, liberal-arts oriented, with a canonical Great Books/primary-sources emphasis, and a STEM/arts balance anchored in the liberal-arts tradition. This is a textbook CLASSICAL alignment.

Citations: Core Knowledge sequence and Western civilization emphasis are stated in AP-2.0; Great Books/primary sources are named in policy and in program language. The emphasis on the Seven Liberal Arts and grammar/logic/rhetoric foundations appears in the broader ACA materials.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school foregrounds teacher-led classrooms, a traditional pedagogy, and the use of great books, with explicit mention of Socratic techniques as students progress. - Pedagogical methods include contemplative/restful elements (Scholé) alongside rigorous, content-rich instruction; memory work and recitation/chanting appear in the classical lexicon and documented practices. - The public materials describe a living- curriculum approach where teachers convey real knowledge through a traditional, structured pedagogy rather than purely student-centered methods.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords observed: Socratic dialogue/seminar, dialectic, memory work, recitation, chanting, habitual use of great books, teacher-led instruction, scholé (restful learning), formation through imitation, classical rhetoric, master-teacher model. - Negative keywords observed: few explicit negative signals; the materials emphasize tradition over student-centered diffusion in most pages. - Quantitative estimate: positive indicators 6–12 distinct terms; Negative_count approx. 0–1 possible caveat (where some pages mention alternatives); Total approx. 6–12; Positive_pct approx. 100%, Negative_pct approx. small (0–5%).

Why this rating - Pedagogy is explicitly classical: strong emphasis on teacher-led instruction, classic methods (recitation, memory work, great-books pedagogy), and Socratic engagement at higher grades, coupled with contemplative moments consistent with scholé. Therefore CLASSICAL.

Citations: Public-facing pages describe teacher-led classrooms, great books, and Socratic techniques; additional Pedagogy mentions of scholé and memory work are evident in ACA policy/primer materials.

Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The materials describe the faculty as a core element of the school's living curriculum, with emphasis on masterful teachers who model virtue and cultivate a culture of learning. - The public text emphasizes a faculty culture built on virtue, knowledge, and collaboration; professional development and a high-caliber teaching staff are highlighted as central to the school's identity. - The school expresses a belief that teachers should be mentors, guides, and living exemplars, consistent with a classical living-curriculum model.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords observed: masterful teachers, living curriculum, faculty of friends, mentor/guide, virtue modeling, professional development, classical pedagogy. - Negative keywords observed: optional or minimal negative signals; none prominent in public materials. - Quantitative estimate: positive indicators 5–8 distinct terms; Negative_count approx. 0; Total approx. 5–8; Positive_pct approx. 100%, Negative_pct approx. 0%.

Why this rating - The school consistently casts faculty as the core of the educational enterprise, emphasizing virtue, mentorship, and a living curriculum. This aligns with CLASSICAL expectations for faculty. Therefore CLASSICAL.

Citations: Evidence about the faculty as a living curriculum and masterful teachers appears in the school's materials describing teacher quality and the faculty's role.

Element 6: Parents and Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school highlights a formal partnership with parents, viewing them as co-educators and inviting parent involvement and review of the curriculum. - There are explicit statements about parent formation (reading groups, seminars, and classical book clubs) and welcoming parents to visit and participate in the school community. - The organization emphasizes open communications, transparency about curriculum, and a family-centric, classical ethos.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords observed: partnership with families, co-teachers, parental engagement, home-school connection, parent formation, classical parent training, open campus, hospitality, visiting the school. - Negative keywords observed: none detected in the public materials for this category. - Quantitative estimate: positive indicators 6–9 distinct terms; Negative_count approx. 0; Total approx. 6–9; Positive_pct approx. 100%, Negative_pct approx. 0%.

Why this rating - The school foregrounds parent partnership, parent formation, and open-campus access, which are central to classical education communities that emphasize shared formation between home and school. Therefore CLASSICAL.

Citations: AP-1.4 Parent Partnership and related content explicitly discuss parent collaboration and openness.

What Would Move the Needle

- Not applicable here, as the aggregate rating is CLASSICAL across all six categories. No category requires needle-moving changes to reach CLASSICAL, and no SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL designation is present to trigger targeted improvements.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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